The Department of Nothing

By Colin Firth

Items indicated this way <> are suggestions to convey the story.

****Directing note: at the start turn the clock away --- at the end turn the clock back to the audience.*

Emma wildly fought for passage --- and lo! By grace, she fell upon a door which gave onto . . . The Night Garden: full of eerie beauty and tranquility. Here the wind fell silent --- All around were crumbling walls and sundials, terrible gargoyles. What she didn't see were little devilish faces poking from behind rocks. Then, one of them said, "Who are you?"

Before anyone could answer, this big loud voice from somewhere else, suddenly shouted, "Henry!!!" Which is my name . . .

And then it was just me sitting next to my grandma's bed, probably late for school, wishing Grandma's stories didn't have to be always interrupted. I still wanted Grandma to go on, but that's always when

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she gets strict and says, "No more talking, the session is closed."

Whenever I'm listening to a story I always turn her bedside clock away *(turn the clock away)* so I don't see the time. She says I'm not allowed to, because I have to respect punctuality – but I always manage it.

It's strange, because the place where clocks most can't get you *is* in her stories.

INTRODUCTION

The relationship between a young child and his grandmother is unmeasurable. Henry defines the hours spent with Grandma as the "best thing" and the time away from her and her stories as "time waiting to get back to this place of adventure, love, and imagination."

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So when I came out of Grandma's room I already knew I'd be thinking about the rest of the story until five o'clock. Your life is made of half-finished stories.

There's a name for all this: most people call it real life, but actually it's called the Department of

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Nothing. It's not just one department, but loads of mini departments. School is the Paper Department, where they have this special *doom-paper* so that anything you write on it is doomed. Then there's the Waiting Room of Nothing where you get told *Not now, I'm busy, or You're not old enough yet* and all that.

Absolutely everyone lives there --- unless they get to go to Grandma's room, which is the only way out of the Department. The trick is holding on to the magic to get you through the Department of Nothing.

Grandma doesn't live in the world anymore, because she has to live in her room. Her health isn't brilliant. And sometimes when she's doing a story, I look at her hands, which I know are really old and kind of baggy but they've got paths that lead where you don't know, like a map of mountains and rivers of countries you wish you could get to.

When you go to Grandma's room, it's like exploring with no fence at the end. She makes her room seem bigger than the world outside, which she wants to escape into, and I think it's sad that there's something

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back-to-front about it all. I want to escape to her room, and she wants to escape into the Department of Nothing.

Grandma tries to persuade Mum to let her go out—to church or something. That's what she talks about wanting to do, and she talks about it a lot. Grandma said she felt like Rapunzel, but who everyone's forgotten about. She said, "My prince would get a bit of a nasty shock if he climbed the walls and saw me now, wouldn't he?

I did get detention. When I got there <Mr.> McVittie had started a biology lesson. The thing is, at that exact same moment I was quite sure I saw a Devil Creature from Grandma's story sitting at my desk. He was only there for a second and then he was gone and McVittie was saying, "look at me when I'm talking to you," and then he said, "Don't look at me like that."

Lynne Lassin saw it and asked me what it was, so I told her . . . and it meant telling a bit of the story . . . and you know what? She thought it was very cool

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indeed. And when it came lunchtime she wanted to hear the rest. I didn't mind/

I carried on the story and Deborah Willis and Zena Whitechurch came and listened as well.

I wasn't sure about telling Grandma about it all, because I thought maybe I should have asked her permission or something. But when I told her, she acted like she was about seven. She clapped her hands and kept asking what they'd said, and how she wished she could have seen their faces.

I said, "Why don't I bring you to school so you can see them?" And she said, "You don't bring old ladies to school, Henry." She said I would take her stories out of here and that was wonderful, because that way I'd be taking her out of her room every day. She did this big smile and said, "I'm your muse!"

The next day I had about fifteen people listening to the story. It was brilliant, but I started to get so many questions that it got quite difficult to carry on, without being able to ask Grandma.

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Finally, I told them all about Grandma, and now everyone wants to meet her. So I decided to bust Grandma out of her room. That way she can see people's faces at last when she tells a story and they can see she's real and maybe see other things are real, too --- and the Department of Nothing might not be so nothing.

Grandma did escape, but I didn't bust her out. She bust herself out, by ambulance.

The visit to the hospital was like a visit to the Nothing Department of the Department of Nothing…only more depressing --- like a place where everyone's been in detention for about five hundred years; I was a bit scared. I didn't know what it would be like trying to talk to her, but I really really wanted to know how the story ended. It was a bit creepy 'cause she was in bed and only her bedside light was on and I thought she was asleep, but when I got close to her she opened her eyes quickly like a vampire. I said "Bugger" really loudly and it's the only time I've ever said that in front of Grandma, and she didn't tell me off. I said, "I came to sit with you for a while, Grandma." And she said, "That's

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another ring on your tree of shadows." I didn't know if it was a secret message, or what. Anyway it seemed very serious and it made me say what normally I would have been embarrassed to, which was, "I love you, Grandma." And then she smiled this huge smile, which started out really nice but then it kept getting bigger until I could see all her dentures and then I realized she wasn't smiling, she was poking out her teeth. She reached up and put them in the glass. This always means no more talking. The session is at an end. Anyway it didn't look much like I was going to find out what happened.

The next day all the people who had listened to the stories, because I couldn't tell the rest, started saying there was no such thing as my grandma.

That evening I fell asleep in Grandma's room and I dreamt that I heard her dentures talking by themselves in the glass. They introduced themselves as "A fine set of molars, eight incisors, upper and lower, and four canines with a perfectly sound bite. How do

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you do." And they had this really strong Scottish accent.

I asked them if they could finish Grandma's story and they said yes, but not yet. I said why not, and they said 'cause we hadn't got to the end. And I got angry with the teeth and threatened to pour their water out.

I said, "Are you saying she's definitely going to die?" And they said, "I don't know, I'm a set of teeth!"

I just knew when it happened. I was on the railway line going to school, and it was a bit rainy, and I suddenly got the smell of Grandma's room in a gust of wind. I didn't even think about it; I turned around and ran home.

The house was locked, so I went up the drainpipe into Grandma's room. Her eyes and her mouth were open and her skin was all stretched and her head was kind of back on the pillow. I stopped looking at her and ran out where the woods start. It was all slippery on the gravel from wet leaves and I kept falling over.

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I went home in the afternoon. My mum knew that I knew when she saw me. She hugged me and I cried again.

During the funeral I kept trying to think up an ending for the story. Emma, maybe she goes off happily ever after with Blind Jack who's not blind any more …'cause it's a story. Actually, you know what? Jack could rescue her, 'cause with being blind it wouldn't make any difference, the castle being invisible! That's not bad, is it? So maybe that's the ending.

So it's back to the Department of Nothing but I had one or two tales to tell myself now, and maybe I should try them out. So that's what I just did.

And the session is now closed. *(Turn the clock back to the audience)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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